

Victims are often approached via email, WhatsApp, or LinkedIn, with messages offering high-paying jobs in reputable companies. These messages typically include:

- Assurances of guaranteed job placement.
- Requests for “processing fees,” “security deposits,” or “training costs.”
- Fake interview rounds conducted through chat-based platforms.
- Fraudulent offer letters featuring well-known company names.

Once the victim pays, the scammer either disappears or continues demanding more payments under different pretexts. In some cases, they even extract sensitive documents like Aadhaar, PAN, or bank details, leading to identity theft.

Romance scams leading to financial “Emergencies”

Romance scams have become more advanced with the use of fintech solutions. Scammers target individuals on dating apps, social media, or even matrimonial sites, crafting elaborate online personas. They build relationships over weeks or months, creating a deep emotional connection.

Common tactics include:

- Claiming to be wealthy professionals (often posing as foreign businesspeople or military personnel).
- Using stolen photos to make their profiles appear legitimate.
- Professing love quickly and planning future commitments.
- Fabricating emergencies—such as medical crises, sudden business losses, or legal troubles—to request financial help.

Victims, emotionally invested in the relationship, send money via digital payment platforms or cryptocurrency, making transactions harder to trace. In many cases, scammers vanish after receiving funds, leaving victims heartbroken and financially drained.

Victims tricked into sharing financial details

Another variation of these scams involves fraudsters gaining access to victims’ financial information through deception. They might:

- Request OTPs or banking details under the guise of setting up joint accounts.
- Trick victims into investing in fake cryptocurrency or forex trading platforms.
- Use screen-sharing software to gain remote access to banking apps.

Many scammers also claim to be “fintech experts,” promising high returns on investments, only to disappear with the money.

Red flags to watch for

Too-good-to-be-true job offers

A common warning sign of fake job scams is the promise of unrealistically high salaries with minimal qualifications. If an employer guarantees placement without an interview or asks for an upfront payment, it’s likely a scam.

Red flags include:

- Emails or messages from unofficial domains (e.g., careers@xyz-company.in instead of careers@xyzcompany.com).
- Job descriptions that are vague or unrelated to your qualifications.
- Requests for security deposits, uniform fees, or training costs before employment.
- Lack of a verifiable company website or employer details.

Online relationships quickly involving money matters

If a new online acquaintance begins discussing financial matters within weeks of meeting, be cautious. Romance scammers often:

- Express deep affection unusually fast.
- Insist on keeping communication solely on private messaging platforms.
- Create urgent financial problems requiring immediate transfers.
- Ask for money through gift cards, cryptocurrency, or wire transfers.

Requests for bank details or deposits before employment

Legitimate companies do not request sensitive financial details upfront. If an employer asks for:

- Your bank account login credentials, OTPs, or passwords.
- Advance deposits for background checks or training.
- Payments via unofficial methods (Google Pay, UPI, or crypto wallets).

...it is a scam. Always verify an employer’s authenticity before proceeding.

How to protect yourself?

Verifying job listings through official company channels

To ensure a job offer is legitimate, take these steps:

- Check the company’s official website for job postings.
- Contact HR directly using official phone numbers or emails.
- Look for employee reviews on LinkedIn or Glassdoor.
- Refuse to pay any upfront fees—legitimate employers will never charge candidates.

If a recruiter refuses to provide company details or pressures you to pay quickly, avoid further communication.

Avoiding financial transactions with online acquaintances

To prevent falling for romance scams:

- Never send money to someone you have not met in person.
- Verify the person’s identity using reverse image searches or background checks.
- Avoid sharing sensitive details such as bank credentials, passwords, or OTPs.
- If someone requests financial help, consult with a trusted friend or family member before acting. 